But if you were to listen to former Pakistan prime minister Imran Khan these days, it would seem none of this is of much consequence. Focused entirely on his politics, he is continuing his campaign of rallies in various cities, attacking the current coalition government as a "cabal of crooks", spinning unsubstantiated conspiracy theories about how and why the West conspired against him, and repeating his mantra since he was ousted from office in April by a vote of no-confidence—that the only solution to Pakistan's problems is immediate elections.

In fact, Imran was so unsympathetic to the plight of millions affected by the floods that he initially refused to join in with others attempting to raise money for relief until, he claimed, he knew exactly how the funds would be used, and also vowed not to suspend his political rallies. At a public rally, he also elaborated on the positive side of the floods—how it would make the soil more fertile for agriculture. It was only when there was backlash against his seemingly insensitive pronouncements that political advisors hurriedly arranged for him to run a telethon for flood relief, after which he claimed to have raised five billion rupees (about $22.9 million), most of which has yet to materialise. He also used the figure to taunt the Election Commission of Pakistan (ECP)—which has published a report detailing prohibited foreign funding to his party, the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI)—telling it this was "what foreign funding actually looked like".

The reason for this seeming nonchalance at the country's misfortune is that the former playboy cricketer-turned-born-again-Muslim politician is fighting for his political survival. From the look of his rallies and the results of two rounds of byelections triggered by the resignations of his party members from parliament, it does seem he is riding the crest of popularity—arguably his highest since he became prime minister in 2018—and he has definitely re-energised his depressed supporters after the loss of power at the federal level.

IMRAN'S FAILINGS AND THE CHARGES HE FACES

But that perception of popular support masks some bitter realities. For one, his party's recent triumphs in bypolls are based on winning back seats PTI had already held and given up in protest at Imran Khan's ouster, and it has actually lost a few of those seats. Byelections are, by nature, low turnout affairs, and these were especially low in turnout since the remaining duration of term for the seats is about a year. It is not at all clear that a similar wave would materialise during a full-scale general election.

Secondly, the skyrocketing inflation, which has left people reeling and has ostensibly played a primary role in undercutting support for the parties in the coalition government, is partly due to actions taken by Imran's ousted government. In fact, the harsh and unpopular economic measures Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif's government has had to take—such as raising fuel and energy prices and cutting down subsidies—



AP



GETTY IMAGES